Editing Choices

A successful transition from oral to written narrative requires some editing, if only because the fragmentary sentences and repetitions that add emphasis to an oral presentation will distract a reader. The wide range of variation among these narratives reflects not only their narrators' different personalities, but also their different ideas about the appropriate tone to take in storytelling. The enthusiastic self-promotion of Auntie Afriyie balances the more impersonal approach Madame Ataa takes to describing community life as she saw it. Maame Kesewaa sometimes turns self-deprecating, reflecting "if only I had known," while at other times she gleefully explains that she did know exactly what to do.

I had to carefully weigh the impact of my editing decisions on the accuracy and accessibility of the published narratives, for fear of negating the very reasons life stories are so effective. I have edited these interviews with the lightest hand I felt was consistent with general readability, to allow readers to learn from the expressive choices the narrators made.

Some speakers seem more concerned than others to tell an entertaining or gripping tale. Their topical and stylistic choices reflect Asante verbal aesthetics and local humor. Sister Buronya and Maame Kesewaa took an ironic tone that skewered the foibles of relatives and colleagues as effectively as an *Anansesɛm.* Asante comedic traditions also include the concert party (a kind of traveling musical theater), standup comedians at the Cultural Center in Kumasi, and Twi sitcoms on national public television (Cole 2001). Madame Ataa used sharp sarcasm to express her cynical views of popular concepts of progress or modernization. Amma Pokuaa and Abenaa Adiiya turned to melodrama or pathos to underline their misfortunes, in highly emotional accounts that hit even harder than the dramatic events they lived through.

The structure of these narratives tells its own story about how these speakers imagine the reader learning their intended lesson. Several stories return repeatedly to their central themes over the length of the narrative, even seeming disorganized or disjointed. By arranging these themes in different ways in successive sequences, they gradually and indirectly guide the reader to draw complex connections between them. Since an Asante narrator expects the listener to figure out such connections without direct prompting, the cumulative momentum of this pattern of argumentation makes sense and complements the didactic statements placed at intervals within it. This iterative rhetorical path creates a spiral logic that mimics and provokes the lived intellectual process.

When I first returned to Kumasi after recording these stories, I brought back transcripts and translations and invited the narrators to participate in the editing process by commenting on the Twi transcripts, which were read aloud to them. It soon became clear that they were only interested in confirming the accuracy of the transcripts. Only the two youngest narrators asked to delete one incident each, which they thought might offend family members. I accepted this apparent indifference with more grace as I began to realize how thoroughly they had already edited their oral presentations to their own satisfaction. As mature Asante women, they constantly practice placing implicit messages in oral narratives in many important contexts, and they took responsibility for saying what was appropriate to the audience the first time. At the same time, their stance challenged me to take responsibility for my own work, by defining the transformation from an oral to a written medium as my job. Their trust in my honest intentions and my competence to implement them remains a cherished compliment, although my pleasure at it is tempered with enough realism about my abilities and character that I hope the inevitable limitations will not be felt as a betrayal.

The degree to which questions from myself and my interview assistant appear in the edited narratives reflects a compromise. Including them can break the momentum of the argument and distract attention away from the narrator herself, but deleting all dialogue can obscure significant power dynamics of narration, recording, and translation. In some published cases a dialogic presentation succeeds brilliantly, allowing a more multilayered interpretation of the subject matter to emerge (Mbilinyi 1989). In another, erasing these dialogues fed controversy over who initiated topics and controlled their sequence, and who possibly distorted major issues (Menchú 1984). I decided upon a middle path, preserving the dialogic content at moments of contestation over its direction or over the meaning of particular episodes. At these points, the other speakers' words appear in italics, attributed to my interview assistant Mrs. Mary Appiah (noted as MA) or myself (noted as GC).

Most of the time, when the narrative flows smoothly without them, our questions are edited out.

Translation Issues

In this volume, as in so many others, the imperfect filter of language translation is also a necessary step to reach a wider audience. A literal translation would not be accurate in effect, because its awkwardness would misrepresent the fluency of the original speech. One that distanced the reader by sounding too exotic or discouraged readers because it was difficult to follow would defeat the purpose of bringing traders' insights more powerfully into focus. I have tried to strike a balance between transmitting an accurate impression of their narrative skill and transmitting accurately the insights inscribed in their Twi word usages and turns of phrase.

Capturing the nuances of form and expression was only possible through the efforts of the reliable and gifted research assistants I was able to hire to transcribe and translate the taped interviews. Mrs. Mary Appiah, who also assisted in conducting the interviews, and Mr. K. Asiedu acquired their Twi literacy in the schools of the Presbyterian Church of Ghana. Mr. A. K. Yeboah had studied Twi to the college level and taught Twi for many years at Asanteman Secondary School before retiring to work as a consultant teacher. Younger applicants for the work had computer skills but could not match their fluency and accuracy in written Twi. They patiently wrote the original Twi interviews out in longhand and then translated that transcript into formal English word for word. They showed incredible patience in deciphering barely audible passages in consultation with each other.

To better capture the vivid forcefulness of the original oral performances, I consulted their Twi and English versions to produce a more colloquial English translation that flows with some of the smoothness and naturalness of the original Twi. This leaves me completely responsible for the final wording, rather than my three translators. In the appendix, readers can evaluate the editing process by comparing parallel passages from all three versions. The tapes, transcripts, and translations remain available on request for future linguists to analyze.

The raw transcripts of these interviews were dotted with bursts of repetition of phrases or whole sentences, either in immediate succession

or after a short interval, that were clearly a deliberate rhetorical device. Sometimes the effect seemed musical or rhythmical, like a refrain. In many cases I abbreviated these chains of repetition because they lose their intended effect in written form. In Twi, they also harmonize with other repetitive structures within the language. Reduplication is a prominent grammatical feature of Akan languages, used to express continuation over time and to replace English adverbs like "very." English (written or oral) uses repetition much more sparingly, so preserving this feature intact made the speakers sound defensive or confused. I have therefore retained it sparingly, when the emphasis seemed most critical.

Another judgment call concerned the frequent interjections of phrases that refer to the listener. Because they add so much interactive flavor to the narratives, I was reluctant to remove all instances of "you see?" (*wahu?*) and "do you understand?" (*woate aseɛ?*). Instead, I left them in Twi, in order to signal how commonplace such usage is in Twi. Another very common phase, "it means" (*kyerɛ seɛ*), can be interjected much like the English phrase "I mean," but that carries an unfortunate connotation of witlessness in the United States. One narrator used it so often that leaving at least one in each line made her seem ridiculous. In this case I decided to omit most of the interjections and translate only those that formed part of a normal sentence. Conversely, simply translating the interjection "Father!" (*Agya!*) into English conveyed little of its wide range of meanings. These include something like the stereotypical Italian *Mamma mia,* but with many other gradations of appeal or surprise.

The narrators themselves sprinkled some English words into their Twi speech, notably "time" and "civilization." Kumasi residents are notorious for using relatively many English words, especially kin terms like "papa," "maame" (the local spelling of the loan word "mama"), "sister," and "auntie." Words that were originally in English are shown in **boldface**, to distinguish them from translations from Twi. Also, Ghanaians give some English words a markedly different meaning or connotation than they have in the U.S. The Twi equivalents cover a wider range of collateral relatives; for example, *ɛna* refers correctly to both one's mother and her sisters. In practice, the English terms are used much more casually as fictive kin terms for acquaintances of appropriate age and gender, though they are also widely used for immediate relatives. Any adult man or woman can be politely called Papa or Maame, and one's own mother might be usually called Auntie. By contrast, the Twi term *ɛna* is rarely

used loosely, but only for those in the appropriate relationship. English words with distinctive usages appear in the glossary together with Twi words, for easy reference.

Both English and Twi terms related to development concepts will receive special attention, including the noun *anibue* ("eye-opening" or "enlightenment") and the verbs *kɔ so* and *kɔ w'anim* ("to move on or get ahead," hence "progress"). The colonial transplant "civilization," like other English loan words, carries different meanings and connotations to the localized ear and the novice reader, and thus requires discreet annotation to prevent misunderstanding (Chernoff 2004). Signs of the opposite process, degeneration, were often condemned as *basabasa*. In translation of such terms here, I have looked for an English word with a similar meaning in the specific context, while noting the original Twi used.

The same warning applies to the events and comparisons within the narratives. A life history can appear deceptively unmediated and self-explanatory, but readers actually interpret it in relation to their pre-existing knowledge. It draws its listener in through an identification with the narrator that creates complicity and starts to build an imagined community (Behar 1993). By the same process, the "false intimacy" of the genre intensifies the danger of appropriation and exoticization by glossing over any power differences existing between narrator, recorder, and other mediators (Ong 1988). The harmful stereotypes of African women widely promulgated in textbooks and public media make such interpretations less likely to be accurate, although they may seem to be clear and obvious because they are based on past experience. To disarm these learned assumptions and allow a life history to have full impact on a more general public, the background information that follows needs to address the most common misconceptions directly, while outlining the basic framework of economic, cultural, and political institutions.

Historical Context

Life histories preserve and highlight the uniqueness of individual perspectives and personal agency, as these interact with the wider sweep of historical events and social structures. They can empower narrators without the literacy or time to write an autobiography, by inserting their